Yad Hanadiv × MindCET

Meeting Summary

From System-Oriented to Learner-Oriented EdTech

Yad Hanadiv × MindCET shared-learning series · Session 1 of 6 · Jerusalem, 15.10.2026

Overview

The first of six shared-learning sessions, organized by Yad Hanadiv and MindCET and hosted by Avi Warshavsky, opened by Moti Taubin of Yad Hanadiv, brought together investors, researchers, entrepreneurs and people from the Ministry of Education, the National Library and philanthropy. The day opened with a call to look back honestly at what EdTech promised and delivered before AI drives the next wave of investment, and continued with three fireside chats: Josh Schwartz on 25 years of EdTech investment, Prof. Arnon Hershkovitz on data and educators, and Prof. Sheizaf Rafaeli on networks and links.

Key takeaways

- Equal opportunity is the goal; technology is the means. The question is no longer whether AI enters the classroom, but whom it will serve.
- Before scaling AI, the field should understand which EdTech promises failed and which assumptions about students, teachers and schools were too simple.
- Ask simple but demanding questions of every solution: Does it work? For whom? Under what conditions? At what cost?
- The best product doesn't always win: distribution in K-12 is hard, slow and capital-intensive, and impact needs patient, bridging capital.
- Teachers barely use school data systems; data helps only when it serves real decisions, and teacher judgment and machine data work best together.
- There is a line between seeing the child as a whole person and collecting data about everything in their life outside school.
- The new EdTech happens outside our control: 'AI agents vs. student agency' was proposed as a theme for a coming meeting.
- Knowledge lies in the connections between the dots. AI risks flattening knowledge and erasing the links; education should make networks explicit.

Session by session

Opening remarks

10:17–10:23 · Moti Taubin (Director of Education, Yad Hanadiv) · Avi Warshavsky (MindCET, host)

Moti Taubin, Director of Education at Yad Hanadiv, opens the series: the shift from system-oriented to learner-oriented EdTech is a useful frame but not yet an answer. Before AI drives the next wave of investment, the field should understand what worked and what failed.

- The series' title points to a shift from system-oriented to learner-oriented EdTech: a useful frame, but not yet an answer.
- Technology is becoming personal, but learning still depends on relationships: teachers, classrooms and public systems.
- Education systems absorb new technology without changing how learning happens; this stability is sometimes a strength and sometimes the problem.
- Yad Hanadiv's strategy: language and math literacy and self-efficacy in primary schools; AI literacy and learning with AI in middle school.
- Mindcet's quality and validation framework, as it becomes independent, can help the field tell innovative technology from technology that improves learning.
- Hope for the six meetings: from curiosity about tools to discipline about outcomes, from pilots to conditions for scale, and fewer slogans with better questions.

Round of introductions

10:23–10:34 · Avi Warshavsky (MindCET, host) · Dr. Ilan Ben Yaakov (Mindcet Labs) · Dr. Cecilia Waismann (Mindcet Labs)

A round of introductions: entrepreneurs, investors, researchers and people from the Ministry of Education, the National Library, the Davidson Institute, Yad Hanadiv and Mindcet. Many names were garbled by the ASR. Avi closes with the story of the tool Ilan built for the conference.

- Participants included entrepreneurs (TeachMe, Capit Learning), investors (East Wind Advisors), AI-in-education researchers, the Davidson Institute, the National Library, the national AI literacy initiative, NYU, the Ministry of Education's EdTech lead, Yad Hanadiv and Mindcet.
- Avi Warshavsky told how Ilan Ben Yaakov rebuilt the conference's live transcription tool overnight, by re-prompting rather than writing code, after Josh called it terrible at the hackathon: a symbol of the changing industry.

Fireside chat with Josh Schwartz: lessons from 25 years of EdTech investment

10:44–11:29 · Josh Schwartz (East Wind Advisors) · Avi Warshavsky (MindCET, host)

Josh Schwartz, an investment banker who has worked in education for 25 years, talks about founders' blind spot (passion without market realism), ReUp Education and PowerSchool as success stories, the capital markets' overcorrection after the COVID bubble, the critique in The Digital Delusion, and what will not be replaced: creativity and inspiration. Includes an overrated/underrated round and audience questions, among them the Ministry of Education's 720 program.

- Founders' blind spot: great passion not tempered by market realities; many don't know their idea was tried before. The best product doesn't always win.

- ReUp Education: coaches supported by algorithms re-enrolled students who stopped out, paid by a share of recovered tuition; it now works with US states on workforce development.
- PowerSchool: bought by Apple for about $62M (2001), sold to Pearson, then to Vista for $350M; connecting back-office data to the classroom made it worth $5.6B in 2024. Transformation that happened behind the scenes.
- Capital markets: COVID stimulus inflated EdTech in 2020-2022; the crash led to an overcorrection and negative sentiment. The market is now more discerning, and AI-native startups find it hard to raise.
- The Digital Delusion (Horvath) is superficial: it lumps all EdTech together as Chromebooks and screen time and confuses correlation with causation, though the criticism is legitimate.
- The best investors care about outcomes, but K-12 distribution is slow and needs research, so patient, bridging capital is missing.
- Overrated/underrated: AI tutors are overrated; adaptive learning was overrated but true personalization is underrated, as long as it keeps social learning; Khan Academy is rated about right.
- Audience: education can't be truly free, someone pays (models like EverFi's sponsors). The Ministry's 720 program: AI-accompanied independent learning, 32 schools last year and 140 this year, with Yad Hanadiv hoping to fund an evaluation with the chief scientist.
- What won't be replaced: creativity and inspiration (Rick Rubin's The Creative Act). His regret: not enough patient capital. He remains very optimistic.

Fireside chat with Prof. Arnon Hershkovitz: data, educators and AI

11:46–12:24 · Prof. Arnon Hershkovitz (Tel Aviv University) · Avi Warshavsky (MindCET, host)

Prof. Arnon Hershkovitz, an educational data mining and learning analytics researcher, explains that teachers barely use data systems: their decisions are intuitive and the systems feel like a burden. The discussion moves to how much a school should know about students' lives outside class, the difference between macro-level data and the personal relationship, and the risk that AI conclusions replace teachers' judgment. Arnon closes: we decide the goal of each lesson, and we need to teach both with AI and about AI.

- From educational data mining to learning analytics: it's not just data but learners, context and processes.
- Teachers barely use school information systems: they get little out and are required to put a lot in. Their decision-making is mostly intuitive.
- Asked what data they want, instructors and principals wish for almost everything, from sleep habits to how students get to school. EdTech data is too narrow for that.
- We don't want teachers to be data-driven clerks; their judgment matters, and dashboards require data literacy many lack.
- An Israeli math study: teacher-led and machine-led personalization gave similar results, because each decided based on different data. They should work together.
- Discussion: 'because we can doesn't mean we should'. Seeing the child as a whole doesn't require knowing everything; COVID and the Facebook era showed students want to keep school and personal life apart.

- Distinguish the micro level (the teacher-student relationship) from the macro level (policy data with guardrails: why, who collects, who stores, consent).
- The next risk is the authority of AI conclusions: descriptive, predictive, then prescriptive analytics. A parent's story of an AI-written study guide and an AI-written test illustrated learning without learning.
- Arnon's conclusion: we set the goal of each lesson and decide where technology fits. Teach with AI and about AI; some lessons can be screen-free writing, others critical reflection on AI output.

Fireside chat with Prof. Sheizaf Rafaeli: networks, links and the connections between the dots

12:24–12:56 · Prof. Sheizaf Rafaeli (Shenkar) · Avi Warshavsky (MindCET, host)

Prof. Sheizaf Rafaeli shifts the spotlight to networks: knowledge lies in the connections between the dots, not the dots themselves. He tells of his path from radio and TV to computer-mediated communication, Ted Nelson's Computer Lib/Dream Machines, the National Library steering-committee debate, and his claim that the most superfluous part of a library is the bindings. Education should teach network science and assess students by the links they create. A participant presents research on links in Stack Exchange forums and warns that AI flattens knowledge and makes the links disappear.

- A self-described 'digitally deluded data fetishist': from frustration with the limits of personal work with at-risk youth, to radio and TV, to computer-mediated communication and early Israeli dotcoms.
- Ted Nelson's Computer Lib/Dream Machines and hypertext: think about the links between things, not just the things.
- On the National Library steering committee he argued for digitization over building; he still holds that view.
- The most superfluous part of a library is the bindings: knowledge would be better if everything in books were connected. References are a ritual we've been trained to ignore.
- 'Everything is miscellaneous' (Weinberger), 'ein mukdam u'meuchar ba'Torah': digital allows different orders for different people; too often we still impose linear structure.
- His Edge answer: networks are the scientific idea that should be more widely known. We still teach normal distributions and correlations instead of network math and power laws.
- In practice, as president of Shenkar, he urges 500+ instructors to assess by links, for example Wikipedia articles graded by their links rather than content; links are social as well as individual.
- A participant's Stack Exchange research shows users who add links become latent organizers of knowledge. AI breaks content into bits and erases the links, flattening how people think; 'you can go from depth to flat, but not back'.
- Proposed for a future meeting: the oversimplification of information.

Closing

12:56–12:58 · Avi Warshavsky (MindCET, host)

Avi wraps up the day's three conversations and promises to send a summary and coordinate expectations before the next meeting. The series' first goal is building the group.

- Avi linked the three talks: EdTech in general (Josh), data-based decisions (Arnon), and the untapped potential of internet culture against EdTech's linear 'closed garden' (Sheizaf).
- Next steps: a summary will be sent to participants for input, expectations for the coming months will be coordinated, and participants are invited to suggest directions. Building the group is the first goal.

Themes proposed for future meetings

- AI agents vs. student agency
- The oversimplification of information in the AI era
- Network research in learning (Lena's PhD)

Note: based on an automatic transcript of variable quality; some names and details are flagged for checking in the transcript.